

MATH 535: LINEAR ALGEBRA

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1. AUGUST 24, 2026

1.1. Fields.

Definition 1 (Binary operation). *A binary operation on a set S is a function*

$$F: S \times S \longrightarrow S.$$

Thus, for every $x, y \in S$, the value $F(x, y)$ is again an element of S . We usually write $x \cdot y$ or $x + y$ in place of $F(x, y)$.

Example 1. *Addition on $\mathbb{Z}$ is a binary operation: the map*

$$\mathbb{Z} \times \mathbb{Z} \longrightarrow \mathbb{Z}, \quad (m, n) \longmapsto m + n$$

takes every pair of integers to an integer.

Definition 2. Let F be a binary operation on S . A subset $T \subseteq S$ is closed under F if

$$F(x, y) \in T$$

whenever $x, y \in T$.

Example 2. The positive integers $\mathbb{Z}_{>0}$ are closed under addition. The odd integers are not closed under addition, but they are closed under multiplication.

Definition 3 (Field). Let $\mathbb{F}$ be a set equipped with two binary operations, called addition and multiplication. The sum and product of $a, b \in \mathbb{F}$ are denoted by $a + b$ and ab , respectively. Suppose that for every $a, b, c \in \mathbb{F}$,

- (i) $a + b = b + a$;
- (ii) $(a + b) + c = a + (b + c)$;
- (iii) $ab = ba$;
- (iv) $a(bc) = (ab)c$;
- (v) $a(b + c) = ab + ac$.

Suppose further that

- (vi) $\mathbb{F}$ contains an additive identity 0 and a multiplicative identity 1 , so that

$$a + 0 = a \quad \text{and} \quad 1a = a$$

for every $a \in \mathbb{F}$;

- (vii) $1 \neq 0$;
- (viii) every $a \in \mathbb{F}$ has an additive inverse $-a \in \mathbb{F}$ such that $a + (-a) = 0$;
- (ix) every nonzero $a \in \mathbb{F}$ has a multiplicative inverse $a^{-1} \in \mathbb{F}$ such that $aa^{-1} = 1$.

Then $\mathbb{F}$ is called a field.

Example 3. The integers $\mathbb{Z}$ do not form a field: for example, 2 has no multiplicative inverse in $\mathbb{Z}$. The sets $\mathbb{Q}$, $\mathbb{R}$, and $\mathbb{C}$, with their usual operations, are fields.

There are also finite fields. For example,

$$\mathbb{F}_2 = \{0, 1\} \quad \text{and} \quad \mathbb{F}_3 = \{0, 1, 2\},$$

where the elements are the possible remainders upon division by 2 and 3, respectively. Addition and multiplication in $\mathbb{F}_3$ are given by the following tables:

+	0	1	2	·	0	1	2
0	0	1	2	0	0	0	0
1	1	2	0	1	0	1	2
2	2	0	1	2	0	2	1

More generally, if p is prime, then

$$\mathbb{F}_p = \{0, 1, \dots, p-1\},$$

with addition and multiplication performed modulo p , is a field.

Lemma 1. *If a is an element of a field $\mathbb{F}$, then $a \cdot 0 = 0$.*

Proof. Since $0 + 0 = 0$, distributivity gives

$$a \cdot 0 = a(0 + 0) = a \cdot 0 + a \cdot 0.$$

Adding the additive inverse of $a \cdot 0$ to both sides yields $0 = a \cdot 0$. $\square$

2. AUGUST 26, 2026

2.1. Further properties of fields. The preceding lecture showed that $a \cdot 0 = 0$ for every element a of a field. We now obtain the zero-product property.

Proposition 1 (Zero-product property). *Let $a, b \in \mathbb{F}$. If $ab = 0$, then either $a = 0$ or $b = 0$.*

Proof. Suppose that $ab = 0$ and $a \neq 0$. Since $\mathbb{F}$ is a field, a^{-1} exists. Therefore

$$0 = a^{-1}0 = a^{-1}(ab) = (a^{-1}a)b = 1b = b.$$

Thus $a = 0$ or $b = 0$. $\square$

2.2. Characteristic of a field. For a positive integer n and $a \in \mathbb{F}$, write

$$na = \underbrace{a + a + \cdots + a}_{n \text{ terms}}.$$

Definition 4 (Characteristic). *Let $\mathbb{F}$ be a field. If $n1 = 0$ for some positive integer n , then the least such n is called the characteristic of $\mathbb{F}$, denoted $\text{char}(\mathbb{F})$. If $n1 \neq 0$ for every positive integer n , then $\mathbb{F}$ has characteristic zero.*

The fields $\mathbb{Q}$, $\mathbb{R}$, and $\mathbb{C}$ have characteristic zero. For every prime p , the field $\mathbb{F}_p$ has characteristic p . The rational function field $\mathbb{F}_p(t)$ is an infinite field of characteristic p .

Proposition 2. *If $\mathbb{F}$ has positive characteristic r , then r is prime.*

Proof. We have $r \neq 1$, since $1 \neq 0$. Suppose that r is composite, so

$$r = st$$

for integers s, t satisfying $1 < s, t < r$. Distributivity gives

$$(s1)(t1) = (st)1 = r1 = 0.$$

By the zero-product property, either $s1 = 0$ or $t1 = 0$. Both alternatives contradict the minimality of r . Hence r is prime. $\square$

Proposition 3. *If $\text{char}(\mathbb{F}) = p > 0$, then*

$$pa = 0$$

for every $a \in \mathbb{F}$.

Proof. Since $p1 = 0$, associativity and distributivity imply

$$pa = p(1a) = (p1)a = 0a = 0.$$

$\square$

Proposition 4. *Every finite field has positive characteristic.*

Proof. Let $\mathbb{F}$ be finite. The sequence

$$1, \quad 2 \cdot 1, \quad 3 \cdot 1, \quad \dots$$

cannot consist of distinct elements. Hence there are positive integers $m > n$ such that

$$m1 = n1.$$

Adding the additive inverse of $n1$ to both sides gives

$$(m - n)1 = 0.$$

Thus $\mathbb{F}$ has positive characteristic. □

2.3. Algebraically closed fields.

Definition 5 (Algebraically closed field). *A field $\mathbb{F}$ is algebraically closed if every nonconstant polynomial $f \in \mathbb{F}[x]$ has a root in $\mathbb{F}$.*

The field $\mathbb{Q}$ is not algebraically closed, because $x^2 - 2$ has no root in $\mathbb{Q}$. The field $\mathbb{R}$ is not algebraically closed, because $x^2 + 1$ has no real root. By the fundamental theorem of algebra, $\mathbb{C}$ is algebraically closed.

Proposition 5. *No finite field is algebraically closed.*

Proof. Let

$$\mathbb{F} = \{a_1, \dots, a_q\}$$

be finite. Consider the nonconstant polynomial

$$f(x) = 1 + \prod_{i=1}^q (x - a_i).$$

For each $i = 1, \dots, q$,

$$f(a_i) = 1 \neq 0.$$

Thus f has no root in $\mathbb{F}$, so $\mathbb{F}$ is not algebraically closed. □

2.4. Vectors and vector spaces. The spaces $\mathbb{R}^2$, $\mathbb{R}^3$, and, more generally,

$$\mathbb{R}^n = \left\{ \begin{bmatrix} x_1 \\ \vdots \\ x_n \end{bmatrix} : x_1, \dots, x_n \in \mathbb{R} \right\}$$

are the motivating examples of vector spaces.

Definition 6 (Vector space). *Let $\mathbb{F}$ be a field. A vector space over $\mathbb{F}$ is a set V equipped with two operations,*

$$V \times V \longrightarrow V, \quad (u, v) \longmapsto u + v,$$

and

$$\mathbb{F} \times V \longrightarrow V, \quad (\alpha, v) \longmapsto \alpha v,$$

satisfying the following axioms for all $u, v, w \in V$ and $\alpha, \beta \in \mathbb{F}$:

- (V1) $u + (v + w) = (u + v) + w$;
- (V2) $u + v = v + u$;
- (V3) there is an element $0 \in V$ such that $v + 0 = 0 + v = v$;
- (V4) for every $v \in V$, there is an element $-v \in V$ such that $v + (-v) = (-v) + v = 0$;
- (V5) $1v = v$;
- (V6) $(\alpha\beta)v = \alpha(\beta v)$;
- (V7) $\alpha(u + v) = \alpha u + \alpha v$;
- (V8) $(\alpha + \beta)v = \alpha v + \beta v$.

The elements of V are called *vectors*, and the elements of $\mathbb{F}$ are called *scalars*.

3. AUGUST 28, 2026

3.1. Examples of vector spaces.

Example 4 (Coordinate spaces). *Let $\mathbb{F}$ be a field. The set*

$$\mathbb{F}^n = \left\{ \begin{bmatrix} x_1 \\ \vdots \\ x_n \end{bmatrix} : x_1, \dots, x_n \in \mathbb{F} \right\}$$

is a vector space over $\mathbb{F}$ under componentwise addition and scalar multiplication:

$$\begin{bmatrix} x_1 \\ \vdots \\ x_n \end{bmatrix} + \begin{bmatrix} y_1 \\ \vdots \\ y_n \end{bmatrix} = \begin{bmatrix} x_1 + y_1 \\ \vdots \\ x_n + y_n \end{bmatrix}, \quad \alpha \begin{bmatrix} x_1 \\ \vdots \\ x_n \end{bmatrix} = \begin{bmatrix} \alpha x_1 \\ \vdots \\ \alpha x_n \end{bmatrix}.$$

In particular, $\mathbb{R}^n$ is a vector space over $\mathbb{R}$ and $\mathbb{C}^n$ is a vector space over $\mathbb{C}$.

Example 5 (Matrix spaces). *The set $M_{m \times n}(\mathbb{F})$ of $m \times n$ matrices with entries in $\mathbb{F}$ is a vector space over $\mathbb{F}$. Addition and scalar multiplication are defined entrywise:*

$$[a_{ij}] + [b_{ij}] = [a_{ij} + b_{ij}], \quad \alpha[a_{ij}] = [\alpha a_{ij}].$$

Example 6 (Polynomial spaces). *Let*

$$\mathcal{P}_n(\mathbb{F}) = \{a_0 + a_1t + \cdots + a_nt^n : a_0, \dots, a_n \in \mathbb{F}\}.$$

This is the vector space over $\mathbb{F}$ of polynomials of degree at most n . Its operations are

$$\begin{aligned} (a_0 + a_1t + \cdots + a_nt^n) + (b_0 + b_1t + \cdots + b_nt^n) \\ = (a_0 + b_0) + (a_1 + b_1)t + \cdots + (a_n + b_n)t^n, \end{aligned}$$

and

$$\alpha(a_0 + a_1t + \cdots + a_nt^n) = \alpha a_0 + \alpha a_1t + \cdots + \alpha a_nt^n.$$

3.2. Linear combinations and spanning sets.

Definition 7 (Linear combination and span). *Let V be a vector space over $\mathbb{F}$ and let $v_1, \dots, v_p \in V$. A linear combination of these vectors is a vector of the form*

$$\alpha_1 v_1 + \cdots + \alpha_p v_p, \quad \alpha_1, \dots, \alpha_p \in \mathbb{F}.$$

The set of all their linear combinations is called their span:

$$\text{span}\{v_1, \dots, v_p\} = \{\alpha_1 v_1 + \cdots + \alpha_p v_p : \alpha_1, \dots, \alpha_p \in \mathbb{F}\}.$$

A linear combination is trivial if all of its coefficients are zero.

In $\mathbb{R}^2$, let

$$e_1 = \begin{bmatrix} 1 \\ 0 \end{bmatrix}, \quad e_2 = \begin{bmatrix} 0 \\ 1 \end{bmatrix}.$$

Then

$$\text{span}\{e_1, e_2\} = \mathbb{R}^2,$$

because

$$\begin{bmatrix} x \\ y \end{bmatrix} = xe_1 + ye_2.$$

If

$$v = \begin{bmatrix} 1 \\ 1 \end{bmatrix},$$

then $\{e_1, e_2, v\}$ also spans $\mathbb{R}^2$, since

$$\begin{bmatrix} x \\ y \end{bmatrix} = xe_1 + ye_2 + 0v.$$

The additional vector is unnecessary, which motivates the question of redundancy in a spanning set.

Definition 8 (Spanning set). *A collection $\{v_1, \dots, v_p\} \subseteq V$ is a spanning set for V if every $v \in V$ can be written as a linear combination*

$$v = \alpha_1 v_1 + \dots + \alpha_p v_p.$$

Equivalently,

$$\text{span}\{v_1, \dots, v_p\} = V.$$

3.3. Linear independence.

Definition 9 (Linear independence). *A collection $\{v_1, \dots, v_p\} \subseteq V$ is linearly independent if*

$$\alpha_1 v_1 + \dots + \alpha_p v_p = 0$$

implies

$$\alpha_1 = \dots = \alpha_p = 0.$$

In other words, only the trivial linear combination of $v_1, \dots, v_p$ equals zero. A collection that is not linearly independent is called linearly dependent.

Example 7. *Consider the vectors*

$$v_1 = \begin{bmatrix} 1 \\ 1 \\ 0 \end{bmatrix}, \quad v_2 = \begin{bmatrix} 2 \\ 0 \\ 1 \end{bmatrix}, \quad v_3 = \begin{bmatrix} 3 \\ 1 \\ 1 \end{bmatrix}$$

in $\mathbb{R}^3$. To test linear independence, solve

$$\alpha v_1 + \beta v_2 + \gamma v_3 = 0.$$

This gives the system

$$\begin{cases} \alpha + 2\beta + 3\gamma = 0, \\ \alpha + \gamma = 0, \\ \beta + \gamma = 0. \end{cases}$$

Taking $\gamma = 1$ gives $\alpha = \beta = -1$, so

$$-v_1 - v_2 + v_3 = 0.$$

Thus the vectors are linearly dependent; equivalently, $v_3 = v_1 + v_2$.

The following result precisely characterizes redundancy in a finite collection of vectors.

Proposition 6. *Let $v_1, \dots, v_p \in V$. The collection $\{v_1, \dots, v_p\}$ is linearly dependent if and only if one of its vectors is a linear combination of the others. Equivalently, there is an index k and scalars $\beta_j \in \mathbb{F}$ such that*

$$v_k = \sum_{\substack{j=1 \\ j \neq k}}^p \beta_j v_j.$$

Proof. Suppose first that $\{v_1, \dots, v_p\}$ is linearly dependent. Then there are scalars $\alpha_1, \dots, \alpha_p$, not all zero, such that

$$\alpha_1 v_1 + \dots + \alpha_p v_p = 0.$$

Choose k such that $\alpha_k \neq 0$. Since $\mathbb{F}$ is a field, α_k^{-1} exists, and we can solve for v_k :

$$v_k = - \sum_{\substack{j=1 \\ j \neq k}}^p \alpha_k^{-1} \alpha_j v_j.$$

Thus v_k is a linear combination of the other vectors.

Conversely, suppose that for some k ,

$$v_k = \sum_{\substack{j=1 \\ j \neq k}}^p \beta_j v_j.$$

Moving all terms to one side gives

$$v_k - \sum_{\substack{j=1 \\ j \neq k}}^p \beta_j v_j = 0.$$

This is a nontrivial linear combination of $v_1, \dots, v_p$, because the coefficient of v_k is $1 \neq 0$. Hence the collection is linearly dependent. $\square$